

INTRODUCTION

As is usual, the classical writers, such as Polybius, make statements about the Celts such as this about the Po valley: "Their lives were very simple, and they had no knowledge whatsoever of any art or science."

Archeology has given the lie to Polybius revealing the brilliance of early Celtic art and craftsmanship. Indeed, Celtic art represents an aesthetic sense fundamentally different from the classical canon which framed the renaissance and modern western conceptions of art. It was one of the greatest glories of prehistoric Europe.

ARTISTIC STYLE

It is by the distinctive patterns of surviving artefacts that archaeology traces the emergence of the Celts before the written records.

The brilliance of metalwork, jewellery, weapons, utensils, wagons and other items shows that the Celtic artists and craftspeople were exceptionally skilled and sought technological perfection in their work.

Celtic arts and crafts began to evolve in the distinctive form we recognise today during the early Hallstatt period. The decorative art is identified by geometric designs, such as chevrons, parallel lines, and concentric circles.

The center of the developing art is found in the Halstatt royal graves in Austria.

Celtic art was basically a design-centered technique developing in the later period with many zoomorphic emblems and representations. There are very few representations of complete human figures on a realistic level such as found in Greek and Roman art.

Human faces did become a popular motif but are generally given an almost surreal appearance. There is some evidence that they were capable of realistic portraits but they appear to have rejected this

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approach.

Dr. Simon James has suggested that, in light of the obvious Celtic ability to make realistic representations of the human body, perhaps human figures and scenes were taboo, much like in Islamic art where human representations are taboo, but design and geometric patterns are used.

In the later stages of the Hallstatt period when trade with the Etruscans, Greeks and Phoenicians opened up, the Celtic artists were influenced by their art but highly selective as to what they took from these sources.

The LA TENE period of art began to flourish with a continuation of geometric motifs whose intricate detail and ornamentation fascinates modern viewers. Many think that the symbolism might have had religious connotations, much like moslem art.

A great deal of La Tene art concentrated on jewellery and items of personal domestic use such as mirrors and combs, as well as weapons and decorated harnesses for horses.

COINAGE □

Interestingly, Celtic coins were one of the richest expressions of Celtic art. They developed their own distinctive coinage by the late 4th century BC. This idea came from the Greeks who were making coins by the 7th century BC. Coinage is to be found in all parts of the ancient Celtic world, with the significant exception of Ireland.

No native coinage developed there until the Christian period was well under way. References imply that gold rings were used as currency.

In Britain, however, coinage was being used by the 2nd cent. BC with each tribe and king issuing stamped coins.

thruout the Celtic world, coins were minted by first casting the metal, usually gold, silver or bronze, in moulds thus they were of equal weight. They were then finished manually by hammering them between two stamps. Most had images that seem to be of religious significance.

Luckily, a great many Celtic coins survive. Most of these have heads on one side and a pattern based on an animal on the reverse. The heads are usually those of the ruler issuing the coins though occasionally there are deities.

METALWORKING

The evolution of the Celts of metalworking was the foundation of their technological advancement. Their proficiency in iron working was a significant step in European progress. How did they develop these skills is unknown but the first peoples to emerge as advanced in such techniques, in the late second millennium BC were the Indo-European Hittites.

It seems the Celts, experimenting over many centuries with smelting and forging techniques, probably arrived at their knowledge w/o outside influence.

In ancient Celtic society, the smiths were accorded high status. They were considered to rank with the professional intellectuals and were thus part of the intellectual caste of society.

The Celtic god of smiths seems to bear a single name throughout the Celtic world, represented by ^{Gō bá nu}Goibhniu in Ireland and ^{Gō fannon}Gofannon in Wales. In Ireland, the smith god appears as a triune god, one the smith, one the wright, and one the metalworker, all three combined to produce weapons or wheels or whatever other artefact came from their combined skills.

OTHER CRAFTS: GLASS, ENAMELLING, POTTING AND WOODWORKING

GLASS:

The Celts learned how to make glass by the 6th and 5th centuries BC but it is only from the 4th cent. BC that the first traces of Celtic glass-producing workshops survive.

Glass was used chiefly in the production of jewellery and other artefacts, particularly colored beads and ornaments.

Glass animals abound from this period, as do glass beads. Several statues and Celtic heads were clearly made with glass eyes.

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The production of glass and enamel in Britain and Ireland had become extremely sophisticated by the first Cent. BC. The enamelling technique would eventually influence the gospel
Omination of the Christian period in these areas.

ENAMELLING:

Enamelling was also carried out among the Continental Celts. The craftsmen had learned how to fuse the glass on to the surface of copper alloys, creating a true enamel working. they used a variety of colors, but the favorite was red.

Some of the most outstanding examples of Celtic art may be found in the mirrors, especially represented by the Desborough, (get picture of this p.140) dating from the end of the first cent. BC. The bronze back surface is engraved with fascinating Celtic designs that could only have been achieved with the aid of a compass.

Very few Celtic mirrors have survived on the European mainland but there are a whole series of insular Celtic mirrors found mostly in Britain.

POTTERS:

Celtic potters had progressed to the use of the wheel from the end of the Hallstatt period. They fired their pots in technically advanced kilns which were designed to allow oxygen to be introduced. the potter could control the color of the vessel

By the La Tene period, the potters often stamped their pots with animal designs. Later the pots were painted with bands of red or white or black patterns such as cross hatching.

The Celts of Britian tended to make their pots by hand, particularly the north Britons. In fact, both the north Britons and the Irish appeared to produce very little pottery preferring to use intricate metalwork bowls or carved wooden vessels, which were much more difficult to make but durable.

WOODWORKING"

Woodworking was advanced among all the Celtic peoples, which
O is not surprizing since wood was their environment. Great forests

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covered all the Celtic lands and once iron had been introduced into their tools the Celts began cutting trees for their homes, towns and roadways.

○ Celtic carpenters were as skilled as their metalworkers. The great trees were felled with axes and split into planks using wooden wedges. From the early La Tene period some constructional timbers have been recovered up to 12 meters in length, along with a variety of woodworking tools, including saws.

Celtic woodworkers were little different from their Roman counterparts in using ~~mortises and tenons~~ or pegged joints. There are traces of elaborate wooden structures--gates to towns, doors to buildings, elaborate wooden bridges (in Gaul).

○ they also produced an intricate range of portable objects, including metal-bound wooden buckets, or barrels.

FABRICS:

The Celtic woollen cloak or SĀGŪM was the height of fashion in Rome in the 2nd and 1st Centuries BC.

○ Cassius Dio, in his description of Boudicca, says that "she wore a tunic of diverse colors over which a thick mantle was fastened by a brooch" Unfortunately, fabric only survives in exceptional circumstances, but we do have a fur cape and wrap around skirt for the 5th cent. BC, preserved in a bog in Denmark.

Other finds from the Hallstatt period include check patterns and the colors, although faded, are reminiscent of the tartan so characteristic of Celtic clothing according to the descriptions in classical sources.

Wool and linen were the main fabrics altho silks, obviously imported, have also been discovered.

Leather working was widespread and leather sandals, shoes, belts and other accoutrements have been found throughout the Celtic world.. Combinations of wood and leather were used by the Celtic shoemakers.

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Once again, we have to conclude from the remarkable evidence left from the ancient Celtic world that the Roman descriptions are less than fair to a society highly advanced in the field of Arts and crafts.

○ Show iV tube - Celtic art history - 6:10

@ 7:35

CELTIC ARCHITECTURE

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There are two popular views of Celtic builders and both are erroneous. FIRST: is that the Celts constructed the great megaliths of western Europe, but as these were built in a period long before we can safely identify a Celtic culture, We must disregard this theory.

It has been suggested that the megaliths might have been built by an early Indo-European people and that these people were proto-Celts, but we have no way of proving this it remains a hypothesis.

*if time, show Stonehenge - 27 min
no later than 30 min after class starting time*

The SECOND view is that the ancient Celts lived in wattle huts, often huddled behind earth ramparts, and did not build anything substantial at all. That is how the Roman propagandists would have us see them. That also is untrue.

Celtic architects and builders, in their northern homelands, were faced with problems that the Greeks and Romans never had to contend with when it came to constructing buildings that would last.

Nevertheless, despite time and weather, remnants still exist. There are constructions in Scotland originally built in the 5th century BC which still stand to a height of 12 meters.

EARLY CELTIC HALLSTATT culture was basically rural and most constructions were wooden farmhouses. Wood being the major source of building material.

on the other hand, the great royal centers were springing up in the 6th century BC and cities were developing. The royal residence was surrounded by clusters of houses and set out on street patterns with shops and other places of business.

Archeologists call these royal sites OPPIDA, the plural of the Latin word for town. These were built in the 6th and 5th Centuries BC, and differed from early sites in their size and the fact that they were centers of trade and crafts as well as providing protection.

On the continent, most houses were rectangular which varied from

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a single large room to great multi-room buildings with a central corridor leading to the various chambers. Sometimes they had two stories.

○ In Britain and Ireland, unlike the continent, most were round houses. The idea of a round house came from the older Atlantic Coast tradition of building.

The British and Irish Celtic round houses continued into the late La Tene period with exceptionally large constructions.

As the La Tene period progressed on the continent we find half-timbered houses often two stories high and ~~so~~ sometimes even three. A Celtic village excavated in France reveals a site occupied by the Celts between 400 and 200 BC with a possible population at any one time of 200-300 people living in some 40 or 50 houses, which were build of stone and timber and arranged in a systematic way.

The timbers show that the excavated houses were destroyed by fire around 200 BC, and the hypothesis is that it was the Romans

WALLED CITIES

○ In the 2nd Century BC, Celtic settlements throughout Europe began to chang pattern and a system of cities emerged. Those excavated show walled cities with streets laid out within, anywhere from 5 to 8 Kilometers circumfrance or so.

Several Celtic towns have been excavated or are in the process of being excavated. those that were friendly with the Romans were not destroyed as a rule, such as Bibracte^{Bib ract} in southern Gaul.

Another Continental town destroyed by the Romans was Numantia^{Năm an tĩa} in Spain. It was the capital of the Arevaci^{Ar ẽ và chee} and occupied from ancient times but at its height in the 3rd century BC. It had well defined streets, foundations of stone, timber and clay. It was destroyed in 133 BC when the Romans starved them into surrender. The town was then systematically destroyed and the occupants were sold into slavery.

There are several important sites of cities from an archaeological
oint of view. A couple of the more interesting are Gergovia^{Ger gĩa}, the

home town of Vercingetorix^{Ver cin ge tor ix} and an Arverni^{Ar ver nee} stronghold. which never fell to caesars seige tactics.

Another is Alesia^{A le se a} where Vercingetorix had to face the starvation of his people or surrender to Caesar. This site was so important, occupying the slopes of Mont Auxois^{Au cay}, that it was still used after Vercingetorix surrendered it to Caesar, and was not abandoned by its inhabitants until the middle ages.

There are a number of very important sites of Celtic cities currently under excavation.

CELTIC FORTIFICATIONS;

In the last decades of the 1st Century BC, as the Celts were being forced westward by the pressure of the incoming Germanic tribes from the North and Slavs from the east, some towns developed a "scorched earth" policy. Thus when Caesar attacked the Helvetii and their allies they moved westward and burned everything they couldn't carry with them so the Romans would not gain their wealth.

The evidence in both Gaul and Britain is that the fortified sites had^{gen} generally fallen into disuse during the late La Tene period. Having no enemies, the Celts often lived in unwalled farming communities or in the great cities.

Then, firstly with the threat from the Romans and then with the threat from the Germanic tribes, the Celts reoccupied the fortified sites and strengthened them.

The excavation of these fortified towns or hill-forts leaves one impressed at the craftsmanship of the Celtic architects and builders.

There are literally hundreds of hillforts and thousands of ring forts throughout the ancient Celtic world. The work involved in moving such colossal amounts of earth and stone is breath-taking.

Of course, we have to allow for centuries of burning and destruction by the Romans and Germanic tribes before we can understand what the face of Celtic Europe really looked like.

BROCHS

Scotland seems to have more surviving stone constructions than

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many other places. The Celts probably built in stone there because of the weather conditions.

The most visually exciting survival of early Celtic architecture is the BROCH, or defended homestead. Over 500 have been recorded with only a dozen of these outside northern Scotland and the western and northern islands.

They are, therefore, considered to be an innovation of the Celtic tribes who later emerged under their Roman nickname Picti (meaning to paint).

The typical broch was a dry stone structure with walls usually about 5 meters thick and with an internal diameter of 10 to 13 meters.. Their tapering shape was designed to give them great strength. There was a single entrance, a door, chambers and one or more staircases leading to galleries. Inside were ovens, cupboards and stairways leading to the various levels.

CRANNOGS

These structures were circular, timber-framed thatched houses on artificial islands in lakes, estuaries or marshland. The majority have been excavated in Scotland but there are several in Ireland, mainly in the north, and a few in England. There is only one in south Wales.

This shows ingenuity of the builders. When the site is located, say in a lake, large boulders were rafted to the position and sunk until, eventually, an island broke the surface of the lake. Great numbers of wooden piles, beams and stakes were cut and incorporated into the boulders as foundations. Then a wooden platform was built just above the water level.

On this platform, the house was built, sometimes as large as 15 meters. A quay was added and sometimes a planked walkway to the shore which usually incorporated a drawbridge as a means of protection.

The main purpose of these houses was to provide their occupants with protection from sudden attack. On Loch Tay there are 15 Crannogs identified. - a tube - loch tay crannog 1/15

In Ireland similar techniques were used. Ring forts, or enclosed

farmsteads, and fortified dwelling places of varying sizes are found thruout Ireland. some 30,000 to 40,000 sites have been identified.

BREHON LAWS FOR BUILDERS

When the Brehon laws were codified in Ireland, the position of builder carried professional status. The ^{ollamh}OLLAMH (professor) builder superintended the craftsmen in their work.

Kings, both petty and provincial kings and the high king-employed an Ollamh builder, who received a yearly "retainer" of the value of twenty one cows.

The law even classifies the work which the Ollamh builder could undertake-nineteen classes in all- and the payment he would receive for such work. Example: 6 cows for building a kitchen for a king.

The ancient law text ^{Crí Gā Bláth}THE CRITH GABLACH, deals with offences against buildings and the penalties they incurred. The ancient Irish recognized the offence of damaging buildings. there was a whole list of offences and the compensation to be paid.

One text distinguished between accidental fire, fires caused by ^{neg}negligence and fires caused by deliberate arson. It laid down penalties for causing death or injury to people and to domestic animals in such fires. St. Patrick in the 5th century AD is said to have preached strongly in support of this law.

Once again we see the popular notion of Ancient Celtic society as consisting of itinerant hordes, constantly on the move from one area of Europe to another and living in hastily constructed wood or mud huts is entirely erroneous.

U tube - Stanchenge my story 19:09 show
Stanchenge Skara Brae - 3:00
if time ~ 10 minutes roughly before 12 noon
8:30

○ In discussing classical commentaries on the Celtic use of heavy wagons and chariots, it has been observed that some provision for all this activity and coming and going must have been made in the way of roads is clear; and it is an aspect of Celtic life which cannot simply be ignored."

Prior to 1970 the evidence for roads was scanty even tho it seemed there had to be an efficient network of roads that existed throughout the ancient Celtic world upon which the Romans simply improved.

Classical writers speak of the use of heavy wagons the Celts used for trading and Strabo actually mentions the roads in Narbonensis^{Nar bon en sis}. Also, Heavy wagons are found among grave goods of the Celtic princes of the Hallstatt period

It is also significant that many of the words connected with roads and transport in Latin are Celtic loan words. Dr. Piggott points out that there are no fewer than 19 Celtic words connected with roads and transport adopted into pre-empire Latin.

This high preponderance of Celtic words in Latin at so early a stage is indicative of celtic pre-eminence in the field of roadways and transport in their early contacts with Rome.

WHEELS

The wheel had appeared in prehistory and reached all parts of Europe long before the emergence of the Celts. Through the Bronze age it had developed from a single cast piece to a hub, usually with eight spokes, set into a wooden curved section in the circumfrance of the wheel, a felly, made up of two strips bent into the circle with overlapping ends secured in place.

For the Celts the wheel became a solar symbol. Indeed, from 1500 BC the spoked wheel had become a religious symbol in most northern European societies, particularly as representative of the sun.

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often models of bronze wheels are found buried with the dead. the symbol also appeared on helmets, amulets and coins.

CON The Celtic wheelwrights created a new and highly sophisticated concept in wheelmaking in the 7th century BC. They reinforced the curves which were joined with iron clamps with spokes penetrating the inner and outer felly and this was then bound with an iron tire attached with large headed nails.

What was most intriguing was this iron tire was made too small for the wheel but when heated, the smithies knew, that iron expanded with heat and the tire could be forced over the wheel and would burn itself into position. On cooling it contracted and bound the wheel tightly.

The Celts were now able to produce wheels that could carry a range of weapons and chariots far superior to those of their neighbors.

ROADWAYS

heavy Julius Caesar's preoccupation with the movement of British Celtic war chariots certainly implies the existence of a good road system in Britain. He speaks of their tactic of retiring a short way to hide in dense thickets, waiting for caesar's cavalry to venture too far and then they would come out of the woods by "well known lanes and pathways" and deliver formidable attacks, hoping by this means to keep them afraid to go far afield.

However, heavy, iron-tired chariots could not have been used in the manner that Caesar described w/o good roads, and evidence for the sophistication of Celtic roads was discovered in the mid 1980s

In the early 80s in central Ireland, traces of a roadway were discovered. It was wooden based but preserved by the conditions in a bog. Archaeologists began excavating in 1985 and when the timbers were sent for carbon dating all the samples pointed to a tree-felling date of about 148 BC.

○ This was not the first road to be discovered, but it was the first to

impinge on the minds of scholars.

Only in bogland conditions was any evidence of them preserved. ^{most} ~~of~~ the roads had been overlaid by Roman engineers, working with more enduring stone. Everyone had assumed that it was the Romans who had initially constructed these roadways, whereas in fact they were merely strengthening an existing road system laid out by the Celts.

CORLEA, as the road discovered in the 80's was called, is the largest stretch of early Celtic roadway which has survived. But it is not unique. Similar roads have been found in other parts of the Celtic world such as in Dummer, south of Oldenburg, in Lower Saxony, where the road, in former peatland, shows remarkable similarities of construction.

The oldest Celtic roadways have been found in Gwent, in southern Wales; these are also of wooden construction and are laid across the mudflats adjacent to the Severn. The first of these to be found, called the Upton track, has been radiocarbon dated to around 410 BC.

There is an abundance of terms for a road in old Irish, each name apparently denoting the size and quality of the road.

The ancient Irish were very particular and used no fewer than seven categories ranging from the ^{slig} SLIGE to a ^{Lam ró ta} LAMROTA, a term for a small byway literally meaning a hand-road, ie being made for a single-horsed chariot.

The BREHON LAWS state that the king or chief of the territory through which the road ran was responsible for its upkeep. If a traveller was injured on the road, compensation had to be paid. If the traveller himself did damage to the road, he had to pay damages to the king or chief.

All roads had to have three major renovations, during the winter, at the time of the fairs or horse racing, and during a time of war.

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There was a system of bridges which also had to follow precise rules on the construction and maintenance of these bridges.

○ Obviously the Celtic world was open to land trade and the movement of goods in heavy wagons. Additionally however, the Celts built river-going craft and traders moved easily along the great Celtic river routes, the Danube, the Rhine, the Rhone, the Seine, the Loire and the Po.

SEAFARING

Were they a sea going people? At least one area of the Celtic world was, otherwise they would not have made it to Britain and Ireland. The migrations of the Belgae^{Belgae} and those from the Iberian peninsula would never have occurred.

Here Julius Caesar gives the most detailed account: He describes the Veneti^{Veneti} as the most powerful tribe on the coast of western Gaul. They had a large fleet of ships, which frequently sailed to Britain. They were the tribe who knew navigation. Anyone wanting access to the coast had to pay toll to the Veneti.

○ Apparently other Gaulish tribes also had ships but the Veneti were pre eminent. Unfortunately, archeologists have not discovered any surviving vessels, tho they have found river craft.

In early centuries of the Christian era, the Picts were famed for their fleet, just as the Veneti had been. The *Annals of Tighearnach*^{Tighearnach} allude to the might of the Pictish navy. There are descriptions of a warship from the Dal Riada kingdom in Argyll which was propelled, when not under sail, by 28 oarsmen.

THE BREHON LAWS list three types of ship: The *lér-lóngá* or sea-going vessels, the *bárcá* or small coastal vessels, also called *sérrcinn*^{sérrcinn}, and lastly the river vessels or *Curragh*.. *cúrr* &

○ Certainly in the early Christian period the Irish were making many expeditions to Britain, travelling to Cornwall and establishing larger colonies, including the kingdom of Dal Riada in Scotland. Irish

traders and missionaries were also making thier presence felt in Europe.

○ As the early Irish texts speak of their ancesters arriving from the Iberian peninsula, and as the Iberian peninsula was settled by the Celts by the start of the first millennium BC, the use of sea-going ships must have been well established among the Celts.

CONCLUSION:

When the Romans found that Hannibal proposed to march from the southern Iberian peninsula, through southern Gaul, across the Alps and into Cisalpine Gaul, they sent ambassadors to prevent the Celtic tribes supporting Carthage, but found that all these tribes shared a sense of unity against Rome.

Shortly afterwards, the Greek senate of Marseilles asked their Celtic neighbors to contact the celts dwelling in Galatia (the central plain of Turkey) and ask them not to act with hostility.

However, the solidarity of the Celtic peoples, even when distant from one another, is sufficiently explained by the sense of kinship, of ^{com}mon origin acting in a fairly restricted world, all the parts of which were in communication.

For that ancient world to be in communication to the extent which these references imply, it would have been essential that the celts had an efficient transport system, via roads and shipping.

~~update~~ time to -10 my ~~for~~ ~~rough~~ ~~h~~ ~~vertical~~ Discoveries
8:33 -
includes - Skara Brae, Stone henge, Gablek: Tepe